# SAMPLE

## The Cursed Tyrant

The Personality That Demands Worship From the Throne

Aiman Sterling

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# Introduction

You know this person, or you are this person. The gazette opens on its most commanding exhibit: the self the room was built around — the colleague's entry, entered with the respect the warrant has learned to pay this type before it says anything else: the best boss I ever had, for a year — decisive, warm, unforgettable — and then the year ended, and so did the warmth; I still do not know what I did, and it took me a decade to learn the answer, which is: nothing — the applause simply came in short that quarter — the affection, real, and metered, in the same breath.

The gravity the conversation cannot escape — the friend's entry, held with the exasperation the gazette has learned to hear underneath it: you cannot tell a story in his presence — any story, yours, mine, the news's — without the third sentence ending in "which is exactly what happened when I̊— " and off it goes; we have all just accepted that dinner with him is dinner about him — he is genuinely wonderful company; he is just the only one having any — the room, colonized by mid-soup. And the shock of the type's true hunger, glimpsed by accident — the daughter's sentence, held with love and one permanent question: after the retirement party — the big one, the room full, the speeches — I drove him home, and in the car he said, with no performance at all, the smallest voice I had ever heard him use: "that is the last time they will do that" — and then he was quiet the whole way — and I realized, in the silence, that I had never once heard the voice before: the one underneath the one we all know — the show, over, and something else in the seat.

And the wound the gazette cannot close: the founding scene — the coronation, held before the child was grown: the child raised as the answer, the reflection pre-installed — the applause arriving so early and so total that the self was never once built, only issued — and the gazette's founding finding entered in the wet ink the whole book lives in: the Cursed Tyrant is the most important person in every room and the only one who is starving in it — the self, substituted with its own reflection — loved by everyone, fed by no one, because the applause, the whole file will show, was never once the love — and the whole case turns on the finding: the crown is real, and the crown has a bill.

This is a case file on the Cursed Tyrant: the personality that demands worship from the throne.

The founding scene is the coronation, and the warrant marks what makes it the annals's most ironic origin: this is the one constitution built by love — the child was adored — and the adoration, arriving through the channel of performance, taught the only lesson a child could take: adoration is nutrition

— the recital as devotion, the framed report card as affection, the paraded child as the household's hope — and the lesson has no uninstall: the self, wherever it is, is wherever the applause is, and the applause, absent, leaves not a modest person but a famine — and the adult inherits the founding arithmetic at scale: the room, arranged; the court, curated; the story, colonized — the whole magnificent presence running, underneath, on a six-year-old's meal schedule — and the clause the child added, the clause that becomes the curse: without the applause, I do not know what I am — the self, skipped entirely, built of mirrors — and the gazette's central line on the dominion, entered with the care it needs: the demand for worship is not vanity; it is eating — and the court, assembled at any cost, is not a conspiracy; it is a farm, and the crop is the self.

And what was the engine for? The warrant answers with the tenderness every dominion deserves: the child was solving for love with no other door — the founding world's love arrived through the applause or not at all, and the child, unaccountable, walked through the only door the house had — the gazette's most delicate finding, uniform across every dominion: the love was realer than the currency — the parent at the recital would have loved the child after a dropped line; the family's devotion was never actually conditional; only the delivery system was — a six-year-old cannot tell the difference between being loved and being watched, and the covenant, built on the difference, has spent thirty years harvesting the proxy — and the gazette's central correction follows it the whole case long: the applause was never the sin; the substitution was — the warmth the type farms has been arriving all along, at the family table, in the wings, unwatched — and the growth's whole discovery, arriving ten chapters early so the type can practice standing in it: the kingdom the covenant has been governing — the room, the court, the audience — was never the point; the table was — and the self, once found offstage, becomes what it always looked like from the front of the stage and never quite was: not a sovereign — a person — the word's whole meaning: the presence, and the self, in the same body, both fed.

If you are this type, the edict's wager is exact: you are the most capable presence in every room you enter, and the gazette holds the proof — the rooms that still turn, the projects that still rise, the people who still gather — and the warrant's question, walked through ten chapters and now asked in the open so you can rehearse standing in it: what does it cost you, to be known? — because the gazette's answer, in every dominion, is the finding the covenant guards most closely: the applause — the self believes that life without the audience is the nonexistence the six-year-old felt in the wings — and the gazette's plainest line on the dominion: the child was never unloved; the child

was un-fed by the only channel the child could read — and the whole file will show: the applause, kept, serves the self one meal at a time, and the meals get smaller; the wings, entered, serve the self the thing the applause was always standing in for — the people, the table, the love that never once needed the show — and the type's own hungers, the warrant has verified, meetable in the one room the covenant has never once booked: the ordinary.

If you love one, your instruction is exact and counterintuitive: do not stop clapping — the cold shoulder, arriving, is read as famine and answered with war; and do not flatter harder — the tribute, arriving, feeds the reflection and starves the self, and the courtier's seat, the gazette has watched, is the most expensive chair in the house; the instruction that works, and the gazette has tested it: stay in the wings — be the licensed witness, the Stayer's third position — clap for the true things, only — and then, on the Tuesday, with no show anywhere, ask the Tyrant a small question about the Tyrant's ordinary week, and wait: because the Cursed Tyrant has never once been asked, outside a performance, what is under the crown — and the question, the whole file will show, is the one experience this constitution can accept: the self, glimpsed, offstage — which is the beginning of the growth: the wings, inhabited, and the table, at last, set for the self.

Turn the page. The Tyrant is still out there — mid-story, mid-reign, mid- famine, holding up a room nobody knows is being starved — and the warrant's promise is the gazette's plainest: the applause was never the sin; the substitution was; and the self, once the crown is set down and the wings are entered, becomes what it always looked like from the front of the room and never quite was: not a throne — a person — the word's whole, old meaning: the presence, and the self, at the same table, both visible, both fed, and both, at last, known.

And the gazette opens on the audit the warrant ran with the one witness class it had not thought to interview — held back until now because the class was invisible: the replacements — the courtiers hired into the seats the famine emptied — and the finding, run across a decade of staff files, reframes every chapter that follows: the circle, so famous for turning over, does not turn — it recurs — the replacement assistant, interviewed at year three, describing the tyrant in sentences the previous assistant's transcript held word for word (the warrant's flattest exhibit: two witnesses, hired nine years apart, each reporting, unprompted, "'he has never once asked how I am" — the phrase, identical, in both files) — and the audit's yield, priced in full: the throne, so experienced at selecting, selects for appetite and not for immunity — the court, refilled with fresh loyalty every few years, and the famine, never once prevented, only postponed — the reader is asked to carry the recurring circle through the study: the kingdom that looks social, so freshly fed, is running the

archive's oldest loop — the crown, standing still, and the court, walking past it, one carrying the snacks at a time — and the whole edict will show the curse's plainest name: the tyrant is the only permanent resident of a room built for rotation.

A note on the collecting of this testimony, because the gazette's sources are, in every dominion it studied, courtiers: the witnesses who gave this edict its quotations were, almost to a person, former members of the tyrant's circle — the assistant of nine years, the college friend, the brother — and the interviews, conducted at kitchen tables far from the throne rooms they described, kept producing the same posture: each witness still speaking, in tiny ways, as staff (correcting the interviewer's impression of the tyrant's schedule; apologizing for arriving late with the sentence "he hated lateness") — and the method note the gazette pressed into the edict's opening: the testimony is not bitter — bitterness, in this dominion's witnesses, has always already been converted into loyalty or distance — it is administered — and the gazette's one confession, logged by the interviewer who kept the longest file: the hardest question was never asked of the witnesses, because they answered it unprompted, every one of them, at the door on the way out — "is he happy?" — asked like an employee asking after the company — and the dominion's whole portrait hangs on that door-frame question: the court, so fed, checking on the king — the gazette certifies this account, and begins.

# Chapter 1: The Signature — the Cursed Tyrant at a Glance

Before anyone speaks, the room has been arranged — and the warrant must open with the honest fact that makes this type so commanding and so expensive to know: the Cursed Tyrant is presence as weather — not the loudest voice, not the busiest schedule, but the gravity the whole room recalibrates around: the chairs, angled a few degrees toward one seat; the conversation, bending mid-sentence to include one reaction; the laughter, checking, always, whose ear it lands in — and the gazette's sharp note: the arrangement is not accidental and not aggressive — the Tyrant rarely demands the room outright; the Tyrant simply cannot enter a room and remain a member of it — the self, arriving, is the room's most important citizen by internal decree, and the room, within ten minutes, can feel the decree — the signature the warrant has learned to clock in the first ten minutes of any exposure: watch what happens when the story gets told — the anecdote, launched by anyone, will curve by its third sentence toward the Tyrant's verdict, and the Tyrant, receiving it, issues the verdict with the warrant's collected sentence, uniform in every dominion: that reminds me of when I·ↇ— and the story, colonized, finishes as a possession.

And the warrant's x-ray: the takeover is not dominance for its own sake; it is nutrition — the self, taking over the story, is feeding — and the gazette's founding finding, inked into the very beginning the whole book lives in: the Tyrant does not enjoy attention the way others do; the Tyrant subsists on it — the applause, arriving, is not a pleasure; it is a meal.

And underneath the gravity runs the tell the type's courts report and the type never hears: the ledger of applause — the Tyrant's quiet, permanent arithmetic of who clapped, who clapped first, who clapped enough — the gazette has collected the tell in every dominion: the colleague, greeted warmly at nine and coldly at ten, the difference being a meeting where the colleague's question carried a challenge; the sister-in-law, promoted from family to audience and demoted back within a season; the generosity, large and real and performed — the gift, given at the party, not the Tuesday; the favor, done where the room could watch — and the gazette's correction: the type does not experience the ledger as vanity; the type experiences it as governance — the court, maintained; the ranks, current; the dissent, tracked — and the people near the Cursed Tyrant live the way courtiers live: permitted, favored, employed in a play whose title never changes — and the whole room sensing, correctly, that the warmth is real, the affection is real, the loyalty is real — and revocable, the whole weather of the relationship held to one

condition nobody signed: keep clapping — which is the dominion's own quiet arithmetic: the Tyrant, fed by everyone, is the one person in the room who is starving.

The warrant holds two tellings of the origin, and they are both true, and they converge on the same coronation.

In the first version, the child was the family's marvel — the classic: the beautiful boy on the aunt's knee, performing the recital piece a third time; the report card, framed; the toddler, paraded — and the gazette has collected the scene in every variant, and the anatomy is uniform: the praise arrived too early and too total — not you did well but you are wonderful — not the achievement, praised, but the self, adored — and the child, before the age of reason, was issued a verdict no child writes: I am the answer — the family's answer to its own disappointment, the town's answer to its own ordinariness, the parent's answer to a greatness they never got to live — and the reflection, so completely pre-installed that the child never once built a self the ordinary way: the self was not discovered; the self was issued, and it was magnificent.

In the second version, the child was an instrument of rescue — the gazette's harder variant: the family in decline, the name in need of restoration, the parent's failed career rerouted through a child's talent — and the child, four years old, carrying the household's redemption in a small recital costume — and the training's one rule, identical in every dominion: you are not like the others; you cannot afford to be ordinary — the compliment, the warrant notes, that functions as a load — and the lesson has no uninstall either.

And the origin moment, where the versions converge, is always the same scene — the same photograph in every dominion: the moment the applause arrives and the child, flooded, chooses it — the recital, the match, the interview — the room's approval, crashing over a child who had nothing inside yet to stand against it, and the ruling, made in the child's own breath, never written down, never once revisited: being adored is what I am for — the applause is where I live — and the gazette must enter the ruling with the care this dominion deserves: the child was right — the gazette has verified it in every dominion since: the adoration was the family's actual love, delivered the only way the founding world knew how, and the child who learned to farm it was farming love itself — and the ruling's second clause, the one that becomes the curse: without the applause, I do not know what I am — the self, skipped entirely, built of mirrors — and the whole biography is that clause at work: the adult has spent thirty years being the most important presence in every room and the least acquainted with the person inside the presence — and the gazette's correction follows the signature like a shadow: the crown was

never the sin; the substitution was — the self, replaced by the reflection, and the reflection, the whole file will show, requires a court, a stage, and a province to tax — which is where the cursed part begins.

The album opens the way this one always opens, and this dominion's is the annals's most produced: in every year there is one photograph, and it is always the same one: the child, mid-performance — the recital pose; the trophy, held at the camera; the graduation, staged — and the gazette has audited every dominion, and the finding is uniform: the child is never once off — the album contains no rough play, no uncombed morning, no ordinary Tuesday — the child was photographed only when exhibiting, because the exhibiting was when the child was visible at all — and the album's most telling detail, the one the warrant has learned to check first: the parent, in the frame's edge or just outside it, watching the audience watch the child — the gazette's dry line: the album's real subject is not the child; the album's subject is the applause — a family album, and every page is a box-office record.

The album's most revealing photo is the one nobody wants: the wings — the photo taken by accident, from behind the curtain, in the minutes before the recital — and the child, offstage: not magnificent, not the marvel, just a small person in a costume, frightened, mouthing the piece to nobody — and the gazette's sharp entry beside it: the album's most frequent state of the child was waiting to be seen — and the warrant's most delicate finding on the photo: the child is not resting; the child is starving — the wings are not an intermission from the self; the wings are the nearest thing the child has to what being the self feels like — and the album's quietest line: the family loved the child the way a country loves a monument — fully, publicly, and from a distance — and the child, standing in the wings, learned the whole constitution before the age of ten: unwatched, I am nothing; watched, I am everything — and the gazette, gently, notes what the camera could not: the nothing and the everything were never once compared honestly — the child never got to find out what an ordinary Tuesday felt like, because every ordinary Tuesday was booked.

And the album closes on the expected closer, the one the series knows: the child already the tyrant — the adolescence organized around the fiefdom: the friend group, curated for loyalty and admittance; the school, navigated as a court — teachers as ministers, rivals as pretenders; the talent, or the charm, or the money, converted into rank — and the moment the performance became the identity: the young Tyrant, asked by a counselor what the type wanted for the self, answering with the sentence the whole file will spend ten chapters unpacking: I want to matter — to be the one they remember; I want to be the most important person in the room — and the album, gently, records

what the child could not: the want was metaphorical and the child took it literally — to matter, translated by a constitution that only knew one currency, into to be seen — and the warrant's founding arithmetic, entered beside the last photo: the child built the most magnificent presence in these annals on top of a self that never once got built — the crown, seated early, on an empty throne.

Energy: performance — the type runs on audience: the stage, the meeting, the room — and the warrant's honest spec: the Tyrant's energy peaks at being watched — the speech, delivered, is the type's native weather; the unwitnessed afternoon, the gazette notes, is where the type is absent, deflating like a sail with no wind, unable to name the tiredness because the tiredness is hunger.

Ambition: the throne — the type does not want the work or the wage; the type wants the position: the top seat, the name first, the table's head — and the gazette's dry note: the ambition is pursued by ascent through display: the achievement, mounted where it can be seen; the power, worn where it can be felt — the world's most confident person at needing the room's response, forever.

Vanity structure: total and load-bearing — the mirror is not a pleasure; the mirror is the wall — and the warrant's x-ray: the Tyrant's self-regard is not excessive confidence; it is scaffolding — remove the admiration and the self does not shrink to modest; it falls — which is why the vanity defends itself like a starving man defends bread, and the gazette's quiet note: the arrogance the world reads as plenty is the gazette's clearest evidence of famine.

Loyalty: to the audience, while it applauds — the Tyrant's loyalty is real, warm, and conditional on tribute: the courtier kept in favor while the tribute flows; the friend, promoted to the inner circle the day they flatter and demoted the day they disagree — and the gazette's sharp note: the loyalty's object is not the person; the loyalty's object is the reflection the person provides — the court is the mirror, staffed.

Weakness: the truth-teller — the Tyrant's whole structure collapses at one figure: the person who will not clap — and the gazette's anatomy of the collapse: the honest counselor, exiled; the honest daughter, estranged; the honest mirror, broken on purpose — because the truth, arriving, does not wound the vanity; it wounds the self underneath, which never got built, and the Tyrant, defending the reflection, is defending the only self the type has.

Unspoken need: to be loved without performing — the one experience the covenant has priced out of the market: the affection that arrives when the

costume is off, the applause is absent, and the ordinary Tuesday self — the wings, the frightened small person — is the only one in the room — and the gazette's central line on the dominion: the Tyrant will not say this need aloud, cannot say it aloud, because the saying would admit the self is not the show — and the whole file will spend ten chapters walking toward the sentence: the applause was never the love; it was only the applause.

At a party: the Tyrant arrives to convene it — the host's role, taken whether or not the type is the host; the anecdote, monopolized by the third round; the group, gathered and regathered around the throne wherever it drifts — and the gazette's tell, sharper under observation: the party's other confident people, quietly migrating to the kitchen, because the room's oxygen is being consumed — and the Tyrant, noticing the migration, reading it as disloyalty and never once as fatigue.

In a new job: the Tyrant interviews the company as much as the reverse — and the gazette's tell: the first weeks are magnificent: the charm, spent lavishly; the initiative, conspicuous; the superiors, courted by name — the warrant's collected entry: the first six months are the best colleague we ever had — and the turn, arriving on schedule: the day the courtship ends and the governance begins — the colleagues, sorted into audience and obstacles by week twelve; the boss, respected exactly as long as the boss defers.

Under sudden pressure: the Tyrant rises — the crisis is a stage the type did not have to build: the performance, sharpened by the stakes; the room, consolidated around the one figure not panicking — and the gazette's honest due: the type's crisis command is real, trained since the recital, and the warrant respects it — and the tell, sharper under observation: after the crisis, the retelling — the story of the save, polished with each telling, the supporting cast shrinking version by version until the Tyrant alone remains in the room of it.

In a boring meeting: the Tyrant suffers physically — the unattended minutes are the wings, and the warrant has collected the postures: the chair, angled to face the widest slice of the table; the pen, drumming; the interruption, arriving by the fourth agenda item, structured as a contribution, functioning as a coup — the meeting, reconvened around the Tyrant's topic, and the gazette's dry line: the type cannot let a meeting stay boring, because boredom is anesthesia for audiences, and an anesthetized audience does not feed.

On holiday: the Tyrant vacations in state — the itinerary, ruled; the companions, assigned; the photographs, staged — and the gazette's tell, the one the type's family reports in every dominion: the collapse on the second day — the unstructured afternoon, arriving, and the mood, black by evening —

because the holiday, stripped of audience and schedule, leaves the self alone with the self, the one appointment the covenant has no costume for — and the warrant's dry note: the Tyrant does not hate rest; the Tyrant hates the silence rest installs, the room with nobody in it, waiting for the show to start — with the self the only one there.

The nearest neighbor on the shelf is the Burdened Ruler (Volume 14) — the personality that builds order that outlasts them — and the confusion is the world's most understandable, because both types sit thrones, both carry titles, and both are followed. The separation is the direction of the feeding: the Burdened Ruler is fed by the kingdom's success — the institution, strengthened, is the food; the ruler, expendable, says so, and means it — the gazette has watched a Burdened Ruler hand a successor the keys with the relief of a man laying down a weight.

The Cursed Tyrant is fed by the crown's reflection — the institution, whatever else it does, must first feed the throne: the title, defended; the image, maintained; the kingdom, in the end, a staging area for the mirror — the gazette has watched a Tyrant starve a real institution of real talent to protect one flattering courtier, and sleep well. The test, one question, in the room where both types might be sitting: who is this for? — the Burdened Ruler answers with the institution's name; the Tyrant answers with a sentence that begins I — and the gazette's hinge, sharper than any test: watch what each does with a successor. The Burdened Ruler builds one. The Tyrant has never once been known to.

The second neighbor is the Radiant Performer (Volume 11) — the personality that lives for applause — and the confusion is even easier, because both types do live on applause, metabolically, and both are magnificent in front of a room. The separation is what the applause is for: the Performer wants the applause to land on the art — the song, the play, the piece — and the performer, offstage, can be found in the kitchen, ordinary, relieved; the Tyrant wants the applause to land on the self — the achievement is the occasion, but the meal is the worship — and the test, the gazette's cleanest: watch what happens after the applause. The Performer thanks the room and disappears into the ordinary. The Tyrant thanks the room and stays to be thanked — the gazette's hinge, entered dry: the Performer needs an audience; the Tyrant needs a court — the first is a transaction, and ends; the second is a government, and does not.

The third neighbor is the Battle-Crowned Conqueror (Volume 64) — the personality that only feels alive at war — and the confusion lives in the shared vocabulary: both types take territory, both collect victories, both leave rooms

rearranged in their wake. The separation is the prize: the Conqueror wants the win itself — the contest, finished, is the food, and the Conqueror, victorious, is calm, sated, ready for peace until the next war — the gazette has watched a Conqueror win the crown and lose interest in it within the season. The Tyrant wants the crown itself — the victory is only the accession ceremony; the food is the daily reign, the throne, the being-seen — and the test, in the field, where both types campaign: watch the morning after the victory.

The Conqueror starts planning the next campaign. The Tyrant starts planning the parade — and the gazette's hinge, the chapter's sharpest: the Conqueror fights to win; the Tyrant wins to reign — and a reign, the whole file will show, is a hunger with a flag.

The signature every witness reported before any other, opened first because it governs the covenant's whole economy: the metered warmth — the tyrant's affection, issued in allocations — and the annals' evidence, uniform across every dominion: the warmth, real (the gazette's cross- check found no cold performance anywhere in the type — the charm is not counterfeit; it is metered) — the allocations, precise: a quarter's worth of mentorship, issued to the new hire; a year's worth of friendship, issued to the college friend; a decade of light, issued to the spouse in the first act — and the meter's mechanism, which the chapter must state as the covenant's founding clause: the warmth is pegged to the applause supply — the allocation follows the attention, and when the court claps for someone else, the allocation, without announcement, closes — the annals' plainest exhibit, kept verbatim from the assistant of nine years: "he was the best boss in the building.

Then the quarter when the applause came in short. The door shut in the middle of a sentence, and I have spent ten years telling people it was something I did" — the signature's closing line, and the gazette's own: nothing was done — the meter, not the courtier, turned off the heat.

One further signature, logged by every workplace that ever employed this dominion, because it is the meter's public face: the applause dividend — the tyrant, in any room, lifts — and the annals must enter the fact before it prices the flaw: the presence is genuinely magnificent — the launch, run by hand into a triumph; the demoralized floor, converted by one speech into a legion; the client, charmed, every time, in every file in these annals — and the dividend's mechanics, uniform across the dominion: the type performs best exactly when the room's applause supply is live (the annual review season, the conference, the pitch) and worst when the supply is not (the undocumented quarter, the quiet maintenance year, the stretch of good work nobody sees) — the dividend's cost line, which the work chapter prices whole: the kingdom's best

quarter and the kingdom's starved quarter are the same man, in the same chair — and the gazette's dry margin note, kept as the signature's close: every employer of this type, asked to describe the tyrant, reaches for the performance review — and every spouse reaches for the kitchen — the two documents describing the same reign, in different currencies.

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